provided to Adi Dravida farmers to sink wells in dry lands, employ drip irrigation and dig farm ponds. Tamil Nadu is also one of the few states that provides additional incentive over and above the minimum support price for paddy.

People-centric development being integral to the state's growth story, Stalin has launched several innovative social welfare measures. Among these is free travel for all women, transgenders and those escorting differently-abled persons in public transport buses across the state, the Pudumai Penn Thittam scheme as part of which Rs 1,000 per month is given to every girl child pursuing a college education after studying in a government school from Classes 6 to 12, the Rs 7,000 crore Perasariyar Anbazhagan scheme to upgrade school infrastructure in five years, the Innuyir Kappom programme, which assures cash-free immediate (within 48 hours) medical care to accident victims, and Makkalai Thedi Maruthuvam, which ensures healthcare delivery at the doorstep.

On the freebie vs welfare debate stirred up by Prime Minister Narendra Modi when he denounced what he called the '*revdi* culture', Stalin is clear that given the extent of poverty and social inequity in the country, states have no choice but to provide for the basic needs of its people. As he puts it, "To demean it as freebie culture is nothing but social injustice. When so many concessions are extended to corporates, nobody classifies them as freebies. But if one dubs welfare schemes alone as freebie, it means the yardstick for their justice is skewed in the country. Please do not indulge in such word play." He is also clear that the Centre should not impinge on the state's domain and treat it as bonded labour. "Autonomy of the state and federalism at the Centre is the fundamental, time-tested principle that the Constitution has agreed upon," he says. "The Union government has to respect state governments, lend an ear to our demands and fulfil them. Sadly, the present BJP government at the Centre does not do any of these things." Among the grievances the state has is that education, which is on the concurrent list, is now being treated as part of the Union list. Tamil Nadu is stridently opposing the imposition of the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET). Then, Stalin claims that the Goods and Services Tax (GST) has "robbed the states of their fiscal rights". The Tamil Nadu chief minister has had several run-ins with governor R.N. Ravi on the delay in signing bills passed by the assembly. He is firm that his government will oppose any hostile move by the governor and "will not back down on its principles".

As an administrator, Stalin's style is vastly different from that of his

METHODOLOGY

How the states were ranked

The India Today State of the States 2022 study was conducted by Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA), a premier Delhi-based research agency. The robust methodology is designed to rank the states on the basis of most relevant and exhaustive data, covering aspects which are crucial in fostering inter-state competition and upholding the true spirit of India's federal structure. The states were ranked under two broad groups:

↘Best performing states

Indicates latest performance of the state specific to the category

Based on most recent data across multiple parameters

↘Most improved states

#Indicates improvement of the state in the past five years

Based on positive changes (outcome-based) in the past five years

The states were also divided into two broad groups—big states and small states—based on geographical area and population. Deliberations revealed that bigger states have their own advantages and disadvantages vis-à-vis the smaller states. States with an area of over 35,000 sq. km and population of over 5 million were clubbed as the big states and the rest small. Jammu & Kashmir was not considered due to the change in its status. Twelve categories were identified for comparing the performance of the states.

In each category, several parameters on which the states needed to be competitive were fixed. Based on inputs from experts—academia, policymakers and policy influencers such as representatives from the NITI Aayog, think-tanks, policy research organisations, sociologists and economists—125 parameters were finalised for evaluating the best-performing states and 89 for the most-improved states. The relative weights of the